Independence, he took upon himself the responsibility of rebuilding independent India, for which motivated intellectuals were needed. With this in mind, he founded Jnana Prabodhini Prashala (JPP) for the gifted in 1962. When I joined JPP, as it was more commonly known, in the summer of 1974, it was still a fledging institution. The school building was not yet complete, only three floors of the planned five floors were ready. Class strengths were small, my class had only twenty-five students of all streams combined—arts, biology and science. Our teachers were highly motivated and could give us personalized attention. The principal then was Yashwant Rao and the vice principal was Vaman Rao, who was also our maths teacher. Vaman Rao, who later became the principal himself, had an encyclopaedic knowledge of the maths syllabus. You could ask him any query by just telling him the chapter and question number, and he would tell you how to solve that problem.

The school placed great emphasis on character qualities and self-discipline. I distinctly remember that during exams, we would be given the question papers and answer sheets and our teacher would then leave the class. Nobody ever thought of copying from anyone. Whatever marks we secured, we were happy with that. In such an open and secure environment, one could concentrate on studies. JPP was also progressive in the sense that there was no school uniform, Monday to Friday. You could come in any dress, shorts, T-shirt, jeans, chappals—as long as it was clean. Only on Saturdays did we have to wear a uniform—a white churidar, pink *jhabba* (kurta) and white cap, popularly known as Gandhi topi. When I first came to know of it, I revolted and refused to join the school, but since there was no alternative, I had to acquiesce. Pink was something only girls wore! I used to try to find ways to avoid wearing that dress, feign illness on Saturdays or simply 'forget' what day of

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